

Anika

& the Worry Monster



Author: Inaara Keswani

Illustrator: Pandu Pradipto

"Anika & The Worry Monster"

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The airplane wheels touched down with a bump.
Anika pressed her nose against the window.

“Look, Anika,” Mama whispered, “this is London.
We’re moving here now.”

Anika’s eyes grew wide. Wow... tall buildings, shiny red buses,
and a river that curls like a snake, she thought. She hugged her
stuffed toy close. But her tummy felt twisty, like a knot that
wouldn’t untangle.





The next morning, the school bell rang. Children filled the classroom with chatter and laughter.

“Class, we have someone new today,” the teacher announced. “Please welcome Anika. She’s just moved here from Indonesia.”

Whispers rippled through the room.

“Wow... Indonesia? That’s far away.”

“She talks different...”

Anika’s cheeks burned. She clutched her bag tighter and lowered her gaze.

**What if they don’t like me? What if I can’t fit in?
What if no one talks to me?**

At lunchtime, the cafeteria buzzed with noise.

"Come sit with us!" But no one asked Anika. She sat alone with her lunch, watching everyone else laugh together.

She poked at her food and whispered to herself,
"I'll just stay quiet. Maybe then I won't make a mistake."

That's when the Worry Monster appeared. Its shadow
slithered across the table and curled around her thoughts.





By the time Anika walked home, her heart felt heavy.
The “What Ifs” followed her like shadows.

One morning, the teacher clapped her hands.
“Children! Next week is Talent Show. Everyone will share
something they love singing, magic tricks, art, anything!”

The classroom erupted in cheers.

“I’ll sing!”

“I’ll do magic tricks!”

“I’ll tell jokes!”

Anika's heart thumped hard in her chest. She loved dancing. Back home in Indonesia, she had danced at every festival.

But the Worry Monster grew bigger, looming over her desk. Anika gripped the edge of her desk. Oh no... it's getting bigger, she thought.

What Ifs

What if they laugh?
What if you trip?
What if no one claps?





That evening, Anika curled up beside Mama. Her voice was small. "Mama, I want to dance... but I'm scared. What if I make a mistake?"

Mama wrapped her arms around her. "My little star, do you know what my mother told me before every dance festival in Indonesia?"

Anika shook her head. Mama smiled. "She said: when your heart feels heavy, give it the gift of breath."

"The gift of breath?" Anika tilted her head.

"Yes," Mama nodded. "It's our secret power."

Mama took Anika's hand gently.

"Hold my hand. Let's try together. Ready?
Breathe in... 1...2...3. Breathe out... 1...2...3."

Anika closed her eyes and copied her.

"In... 1...2...3. Out... 1...2...3.."

With each breath, the Worry Monster began to shrink.
Its dark shadow faded into tiny specks, no bigger than crumbs.

Anika giggled. "Mama, look! The Worry Monster is gone
it's just little specks now!"

Mama kissed her forehead. "That's because you're in charge
of your breath, Anika. Nothing can stop you when you
remember that."

Wait,
we're disappearing!
Nooooo.





Talent Show finally arrived.
The school hall sparkled with fairy lights.
Children in colorful costumes fidgeted behind the curtain,
whispering nervously.

Anika's knees wobbled. The Worry Monster crept back,
curling around her again.

What if you forget? What if they laugh?

Anika pressed her palm to her heart,
remembering Mama's words.

"In... 1...2...3. Out... 1...2...3," she whispered.

Her breath steadied her. **I can do this.**





The music began.
Anika stepped into the spotlight.
At first, her feet trembled. But then she remembered
the rhythm her grandmother taught her.
Her eyes sparkled. She was telling a story with every move.

When the music ended, the hall was quiet.
Anika's heart stopped.
The whole room cheered.

Children crowded around her afterward.
"Anika, that was amazing!"
"Will you teach me how to do that spin?"

Anika laughed shyly. For the first time in London,
her tummy felt light.





Even now, the Worry Monster sometimes tiptoes into Anika's thoughts, whispering when things feel new or scary. But Anika has a secret superpowerher breath.

She places a hand on her chest and counts, 1...2...3.
In through her nose, out through her mouth.....
and with each breath, the Worry Monster will grows smaller
and smaller, until it's just a quiet little whisper.

A Special Exercise from Anika

(For when your worries feel too big)

Anika wants to share her secret with you the one thing her mother taught her that helped her dance on stage with a smile. You can try it too, whenever you feel nervous, shy, or when your tummy feels twisty

Anika's "Magic 3 Breaths"

Sit or stand tall. Put your hand on your tummy.

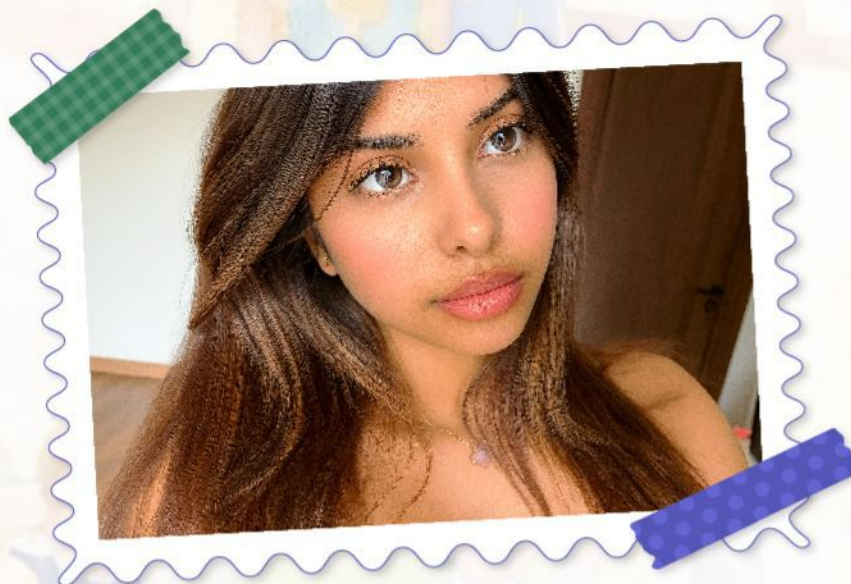
Breathe in slowly through your nose while you count: 1...2...3. Feel your tummy grow like a balloon.

Breathe out gently through your mouth while you count: 1...2...3. Imagine you're blowing out a candle, slowly.

Repeat 3 times while whisper "I am calm. I am brave. I can do this.". Each breath makes you a little braver.

Tip: You can imagine your worries floating away with every breath out.





Inaara Keswani is a student at Jakarta Intercultural School and a mental health advocate. Her goal is to show that asking for help is brave and helps you grow.

She shares tips on her Instagram, **@TaarabyNaara** like journaling and stress tricks. This book is her way of encouraging friends to take care of their mental wellness and to recognize strength in asking for support.





Little Anika dreams
of performing at her school
talent show, but she feels
very nervous.

As the big day gets closer,
she worries she won't be able
to do it. Seeing this,
Anika's mother teaches her
a special "secret move" to
calm her nerves and feel brave.
With her mom's support,
Anika learns to face her fear,
go on stage, and find
her courage.



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